

COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 5

New Patient: Meera – Highly Detailed Version
Full Detailed – Realistic Style with Greater Depth

SESSION INFORMATION

Client:	Meera (28 years, Female, High School Teacher, Therapist:	Dr. A.
Session #:	5 of 16–18	Focus: Behavioral Activation + Deeper Exploration

PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client arrived looking exhausted. She spoke in a very low, flat tone and took longer to respond than usual. She completed the diary on 4 days and managed only one small activity (making tea mindfully). She expressed strong hopelessness and self-criticism. Today's plan: Explore her experience with Behavioral Activation in depth, validate the extreme difficulty, continue with extremely small steps, deepen cognitive restructuring, and assign very manageable homework.

SESSION START – CHECKING IN

Therapist: Good morning, Meera. It's good to see you. How have you been feeling since our last session?

Client: (speaking slowly, looking down) Same. Tired. I did the tea thing once. I tried to notice small things but mostly forgot. I feel like I'm not getting anywhere. I don't even know why I'm still coming here.

Therapist: (speaking gently) It sounds like this week has been really heavy and discouraging for you. I can hear how hopeless and frustrated you're feeling. It takes a lot to keep showing up when everything feels pointless. I want you to know that what you're describing — the extreme fatigue, the harsh inner voice, the sense that nothing is changing — is very real and very common in depression. It doesn't mean you're failing at therapy. Would it be okay if we looked at what happened with the small activities without judging yourself too harshly?

Client: (quietly) Okay.

EXPLORING THE HOMEWORK EXPERIENCE IN DEPTH

Therapist: You mentioned you only managed to make tea mindfully once this week. Can you tell me what happened on the days you didn't do it? What thoughts or feelings came up when you thought about trying?

Client: (after a long pause) Most days I would wake up already feeling exhausted. I would think about the homework and immediately feel this heaviness in my chest. The thought that came was "Why bother? It's not going to make any difference anyway." So I would just get ready for school and try to survive the day. By the time I came home, I had no energy left for anything.

Therapist: That sounds incredibly difficult. When that thought "Why bother? It's not going to make any difference" came up, how did it affect your energy and motivation in that moment?

Client: It made everything feel even heavier. Like there was no point in even trying. So I didn't try. And then later I would feel angry at myself for not doing it.

Therapist: So the thought led to even lower motivation, which led to not doing the activity, which then led to self-criticism and more heaviness. This is a very painful cycle. And it makes complete sense that you would feel stuck in it. Does seeing it this way help at all, or does it still feel like you're just failing?

Client: (quietly) A bit. I can see how the thoughts are making it harder. But I still feel like I should be able to push through it.

CONTINUING BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION – EXTREMELY SMALL STEPS

Therapist: Given how difficult even small activities have felt, I want to suggest something even gentler this week. Instead of setting a specific activity, we can focus on **noticing** one very small thing you did each day — even basic things like reaching school on time, drinking water, or making tea. The goal is to start gently training your attention toward small actions you're already doing, rather than forcing yourself to add "extra" things when your energy is this low. How does that sound to you?

Client: (after thinking) It feels a bit easier. Because I'm already doing some of those things. I just don't notice them or give myself credit for them.

Therapist: Exactly. Depression often makes us ignore or dismiss the small things we're still managing to do. This exercise is about gently shifting that focus — not to "fix" everything, but to start noticing that you're still doing some things, even on hard days. Would you be willing to try noticing and writing down one small thing you did each day this week?

Client: I can try. It doesn't feel as impossible as before.

CONTINUING COGNITIVE RESTRUCTURING WITH DEPTH

Therapist: Last session we looked at the thought "I'm not good enough as a teacher." You said you still believe it around 65%. Can we explore this thought a bit more today? When this thought is strong, what does it make you feel in your body and emotionally?

Client: It makes my chest feel tight and heavy. I feel ashamed and small. Like I want to disappear or hide from everyone. And then I just want to sleep so I don't have to think.

Therapist: That sounds really painful. When you feel that shame and heaviness, what does the thought tell you to do?

Client: To not talk to anyone. To just get through the day without anyone noticing how bad I feel. To not try anything new because I'll probably fail anyway.

Therapist: And when you follow what the thought says — hiding and not trying — how does that affect your mood and energy afterward?

Client: It makes everything worse. I feel more alone and more tired. And then I criticize myself even more for not trying.

Therapist: So the thought "I'm not good enough" leads to shame and hiding, which then leads to even lower mood, more isolation, and more self-criticism. This is a very painful and exhausting cycle. Would it be okay if we looked at what might go against this thought — even small pieces of evidence — without forcing you to believe something you don't feel yet?

Client: (quietly) Okay.

Therapist: What are some small things — even very small — that might suggest you're not completely "not good enough" as a teacher? Even if they feel hard to hold on to right now.

Client: (after thinking for a while) Some students still greet me in the morning. One girl told me last week that she understood a topic better because of my explanation. My mother sometimes says I work very hard. But these things feel small and temporary compared to how bad I feel most of the time.

Therapist: Those are real things, even if they feel small and hard to hold on to right now. Depression has a strong way of making the negative feel huge and permanent, while making the positive feel tiny and temporary. This doesn't mean the positive things aren't real — it just means the depression is filtering them out strongly right now. You don't have to believe the balanced thought fully yet. We're just slowly collecting evidence together.

HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

Therapist: For this week, I want to keep everything as gentle and manageable as possible:

1. Continue the daily mood + thought diary (even 4 entries is completely fine)
2. Notice and write down **one small thing** you did each day (even basic things like reaching school, making tea, or brushing your teeth)
3. Continue rating your belief in the thought "I'm not good enough as a teacher" and gently using the balanced thought we created

Client: I'll try. But I'm still not sure how much energy I'll have.

Therapist: That's completely okay. Just do what you can. We'll work with whatever you bring next time, without any judgment or pressure.

SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

Therapist: Today we explored your experience with the small activities in more depth, and we looked at how the thought "I'm not good enough" affects your emotions and behavior. How are you feeling about today's session?

Client: It was okay. Talking about it made me realize how much the thoughts are affecting me. I'll try noticing the small things I do.

Therapist: That's completely fair. Any questions before we finish?

Client: Not really.

POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client arrived with high fatigue and strong hopelessness. Emotional depth was explored more than in previous sessions.
- Behavioral Activation continued with very small, compassionate steps (5 minutes or noticing small actions).
- Client showed some insight into how thoughts affect behavior and motivation but remains skeptical about improvement.
- Belief in core thought remains stable around 65%.
- Next session: Review noticing small activities, continue cognitive restructuring with more depth, explore values or small sources of meaning if energy allows.

Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.